



Barrier Breakers, March 20, 2026. Students from across Northeast Ohio before the first pitch of the morning.

Reach 8,000 students. Put the top 250 in one room.

Barrier Breakers is FinMango's one-day innovation challenge for Northeast Ohio high schoolers. In 2026, powered by Valmark, we promoted it to roughly **8,000 students in 25+ high schools** across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas through our in-person classroom programming over the academic year. About **250 of the top students** from those classrooms showed up on March 20 to pitch real solutions to the costs that hold families back.

~8,000

Students reached in person across 25+ high schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, where the event was promoted

~250

Top students from those classrooms who competed on event day

\$20K+

Awarded in 2026 as cash to winning teams, grants to their schools, and scholarships

How the pipeline worked

In the classroom. FinMango teaches in-person financial education in 25+ high schools across the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas, reaching about 8,000 students over the academic year. That is where students first hear about Barrier Breakers.

The build. Teams of one to three pick a real barrier, such as transportation, housing, healthcare, or financial literacy, and build a solution to bring to the event.

Event day. Sixty-second pitches to a three-judge panel in the morning. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day in the afternoon, and the cash goes to the teams.

2026 at a glance

Event date	March 20, 2026
Students competing	~250
Platinum sponsor	Valmark · \$25,000
Awarded to students and schools	\$20,000+
Demo Day finalists	5 teams
1st place prize	\$7,500 to the team
Minimum finalist prize	\$1,250

Valmark on the day

Valmark was the presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2026 and was visible to every student in the building, from check-in through the awards.

- \$25,000 platinum sponsorship funded the prize pool
- Two Valmark judges on the Demo Day panel
- Valmark table and banner on the gallery floor all day
- Valmark judges presented awards alongside the panel

Where the money went

Barrier Breakers 2026 raised \$30,000 in total: \$25,000 from Valmark as platinum sponsor and \$5,000 from two additional sponsors to help cover expenses. More than \$20,000 went out as awards. The rest paid for the day itself: breakfast and lunch for 250 students plus their teachers and judges, materials, and the space.

In 2026 a sizable share of the awards went to scholarships through the host university rather than to the students in the room. Scholarships will not come out of the sponsorship budget in 2027. A host university may still offer them as its own contribution, but sponsor dollars go to the prizes and the event itself, managed directly by FinMango.

Valmark, platinum sponsor	\$25,000
Two additional sponsors	\$5,000
Total raised	\$30,000
Awards: team cash, school grants, scholarships	\$20,000+
The day: food, materials, space	Remainder



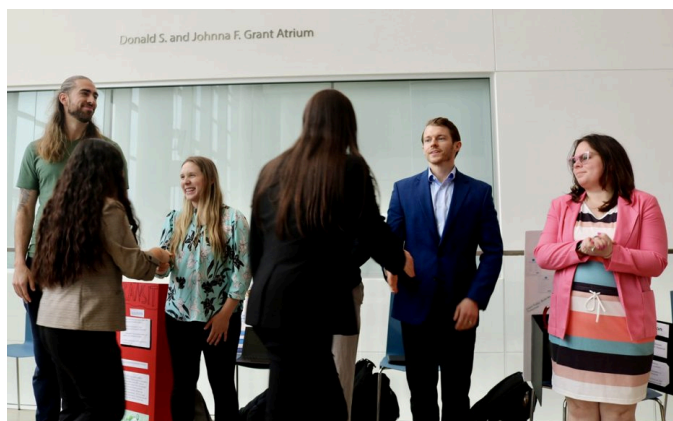
Valmark's table on the gallery floor, where students stopped between judging rounds.



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions from a judge.



Demo Day: five finalists present for five minutes each in front of every student in the room.



Awards: cash to the teams and a handshake from the judges, including Valmark's.

Sponsoring Barrier Breakers 2027

We are asking Valmark to return as the platinum presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2027 at \$25,000, the same level as 2026. The day keeps the same rhythm, a morning of pitches at the tables and Demo Day in the afternoon, but we have simplified the format for 2027: one pipeline for every team, no tracks to declare, one rubric for both rounds, and cash straight to the student teams. With no scholarship component, more of each sponsor dollar reaches the students in the room. The invitation list grows: beyond the 25+ schools where FinMango teaches, we plan to invite many more high schools across Northeast Ohio to bring teams.

~\$100

Per student in the room. What Valmark's \$25,000 worked out to across the 250 students who competed in 2026

~\$3

Per student reached, across the 8,000 who heard about Barrier Breakers in a FinMango classroom

25+

High schools in the Akron, Canton, and Cleveland areas where FinMango teaches in person. The 2027 invitation goes wider

What platinum includes

"Powered by Valmark" naming across the event and finmango.org/barrier-breakers.

Stage time at the awards and seats on the judging panel, as in 2026.

Logo on every banner, flyer, and student handout, and on the recap that goes to every participating school.

First call on the 2028 slot.

A room full of the region's most motivated high schoolers, for a day, with Valmark's team at the table and on the panel.

What sponsorship funds

The prize pool. Cash to the five Demo Day teams. In 2026, \$20,000 and up.

Honorable mentions. A prize for each section's runner-up, so ten teams leave with something.

The day. Breakfast, lunch, and materials for 250 students plus their teachers and judges.

The next cohort. Classroom visits and the teacher toolkit that get schools to bring teams in the first place.

Operations and contingency. Venue, AV, printing, insurance, staff time on the day, and a reserve for the unexpected costs of an event this size.

FinMango is a very lean nonprofit with little overhead. The full sponsorship is invested in the event: prizes first, then the operations that make the day run, with a reserve for the unexpected. In 2027 FinMango plans to manage the sponsorship directly, with no scholarships funded from sponsorship.

Sponsorship levels

Platinum · presenting sponsor \$25,000

"Powered by" naming across the event and the site. Stage time at the awards, a seat on the judging panel, logo on every banner, flyer, and student handout, and first call on the 2028 slot.

Gold \$10,000

Funds a Demo Day prize in your name. Logo on the site and event banners, a seat on the judging panel, and a mention from the stage at the awards.

Silver \$2,500

Logo on the site and in the printed program, and an invitation to judge.

Name a prize Any amount

Fund 1st place or the honorable mentions, and we announce it that way at the awards.

Where 2027 stands

Date and host campus	TBA, new host being selected
Judges	Recruiting now, 15 needed
Schools invited	FinMango's 25+ and more
Student applications	Open once the date is set
Prize pool	Announced with sponsors

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Levels are a starting point. If Valmark would rather fund a named prize, sponsor lunch, or put more of the team on the floor as judges, we will build it around you.